Thaw: Game Design Document

Oct 26, 2026 · @David Babatunde

Overview

Thaw is a slow, atmospheric survival game where a small child, carrying her village's last coal in a clay pot, crosses a frozen world, thaws (melts) what she finds and gathers companions until the whole world warms.

- **Jam:** thatgamejam #02, hosted by thatgamecompany
- **Submission deadline:** November 7, 2026 (PT)
- **Team size limit:** Up to five people
- **Prizes:** USD 10,000 across five categories, finalists judged by Jenova Chen
- **Theme:** A one-minute music track. Our read of it: dreamy and melancholic, cold isolation that slowly warms, a slow heartbeat-like pulse, soft synths, piano and ambient noise, building from solitary to a gentle swell.
- **Theme fit:** The game plays the track's arc. It starts silent, dark and alone, and ends full, warm and together.
- **Target playtime:** 11 to 15 minutes across five stages, starting with a one-minute opening
- **Platform:** Browser (HTML5), playable instantly on itch.io

AI disclosure (mandatory)

- The jam allows AI but requires a clear note in the game description, such as "This game contains AI-generated content", plus what was generated and how.
- Undisclosed AI use means disqualification.
- Keep a running log of AI use during the build so the disclosure is accurate and quick to write.

Our disclosure (for the game page)

> This game contains AI-generated content. The idea, story, game design and level layout are by Ultraviolet. The code, including everything drawn on screen, was written by an AI (Claude) from that design and direction, then tested and tuned by Ultraviolet. The in-game text was drafted by the AI and chosen by Ultraviolet. All music and sound are human-made: the jam theme by Jason Grace, plus CC0 music and recordings from OpenGameArt and Freesound (full credits in audio/CREDITS.md). No audio is AI-generated.

- **By Ultraviolet:** the idea, the story, the game design and the level layout.
- **By AI (Claude):** the code, which also draws all the visuals (there are no image files), and drafts of the in-game text, chosen by Ultraviolet.
- **Human-made, from others:** the jam theme by Jason Grace, three CC0 music tracks from OpenGameArt and CC0 sound recordings from Freesound, all credited.
- **Keep it true:** if the visuals are ever replaced with hand-drawn art, or the code changes hands, update this paragraph and AI_LOG.md before submitting.

Core loop

The whole game is built on one verb, **pulse**: explore the cold, survive it, choose what to spend warmth on, thaw (melt) it, reach the fire, go deeper.

1. **Explore:** The child walks slowly through a frozen world seen through frost. No combat, no jumping.
2. **Survive:** Weather and natural hazards drain warmth. Shelter, timing and route choice keep you alive.
3. **Find:** Frozen objects glint faintly and give off a quiet sound layer that grows louder as you approach, so players navigate partly by ear. A matching faint shimmer shows the same direction on screen, so the game is fully playable with the sound off.
4. **Choose:** Pulsing costs warmth, so every thaw is a decision.
5. **Pulse:** Hold one button to send warmth out in slow rings timed to a heartbeat (about 60 BPM). You cannot move while pulsing. Each object needs several pulses: the ice cracks, glows, then melts.
6. **Reward:** Color spreads from the thawed object, the music grows a little fuller, and thawed wanderers follow you and widen your warmth radius.
7. **Rest:** Each stage ends at a fire that fully restores warmth (Stage 5 ends at the village hearth instead). The walk is saved at the start of every stage.

Design rules for the loop

- Stillness is the skill. Patience beats speed.
- Every stage has a calm stretch between hazards so the mood stays melancholic, not stressful.
- The music swells in calm moments, not dangerous ones.

Warmth system (HP)

Warmth is the child's health, shown by a slim warmth bar and by the coal in her clay pot, which dims and shrinks as warmth drops. The bar sits in the top-left corner, glows amber when full, fades to frost blue as it drains, and pulses with the heartbeat below 35%.

What drains warmth

- Time spent away from heat sources (slow, constant)
- Pulsing (each pulse costs a small amount)
- Hazards and weather (see Hazards)

What restores warmth

- Fires at the end of each stage: full refill and checkpoint
- Companions do not warm you. Their fire joins your pulse instead, so each one makes thawing faster (see Choices that last)
- **Lucky embers:** now and then a warm coal turns up in the snow ahead, more often when you are cold. Walk over it for 15% warmth. It cools and fades after about 25 seconds, and only one appears at a time.
- Thawed trees: once warmed back to life, a tree gives off gentle warmth nearby (about half a lantern), a small resting spot that pays back the 3 pulses spent on it

Low warmth: blur to lights out

Warmth	What the player sees and hears
100 to 60%	Normal view, full glow, the stage music playing
60 to 35%	Frost creeps in from the screen edges, color starts to drain
35 to 15%	Vision blurs, the world turns grey, heartbeat slows, the stage music fades and a darker piano takes over
15 to 1%	Heavy blur, the coal shrinks to a faint spark, near silence
0%	The light goes out to black

Respawn

- No game-over screen. After the light goes out, the child wakes with full warmth at the last checkpoint: the stage start or, further in, the last lit lantern, freed villager or (in Stage 5) the warmed village tree. Never in the ice cave or under the snow, where she

would wake inside a hazard. In Stage 5 full warmth means 70%.

- Restarting a stage puts everything back as it was when the stage began: the record of who was saved and lost, and the companions with you.
- The loss is time and position, and one person: the cold that puts her light out also takes the fire of the last one to join her. They freeze where she fell and must be warmed again; left there, they are no longer saved. The old storyteller, while with her, keeps every fire alight. This is what makes a risky rescue a real choice.

Choices and endings

Limited warmth is the puzzle: every stage asks the player to choose between safety now and connection later, and those choices shape the ending.

Choice types

- **Thaw the path or the wanderer:** A bridge or wall is the fast route. A wanderer joins you and makes every later pulse stronger.
- **Shelter or push on:** Wait out the weather and lose time, or cross exposed ground and risk freezing.
- **Spend now or go around:** Melt an obstacle, or take a longer, colder route.
- **Forks:** two things you can only warm one of, with the question written in the frost. Whatever you crack first is your choice. The cold takes the other: frost seals it, it sinks into the snow and is gone, and the stage end says what you chose.
- **No single right answer.** Each option must be survivable.

Endings (driven by companions saved)

Brought home	Ending	Last line (to confirm)
All 7	Everyone: every window in the street lit	"every window in the village is lit again"
4 to 6	Most: a few windows dark	"most of the windows are lit again"
1 to 3	Few: a few lit windows around the hearth	"a few windows are lit. it is enough to begin"
None	Alone: she lights the hearth by herself	"one fire, and one window. it is a start"

- The ending is set by how many of the seven villagers she brings home: everyone (7), most (4 to 6), few (1 to 3) or alone (none). Trees warmed across the whole game also count: the more of the world she thaws, the greener the final scene. Each stage end shows trees warmed beside companions found.
- No ending is a failure. They are four emotional shades of the same journey.

Choices that last

Choices carry forward. The game keeps a record of who the child saved and who she lost, and later stages and the ending read it.

- **The record:** every stage adds to it. Restarting a stage restores the record as it stood when that stage began, so a restart never erases or doubles a choice.
- **Named villagers:** each wanderer is someone from the prologue's village with a home there, such as the weaver and the baker. The stage end names them.
- **The village row:** the stage end draws the village's homes. Lit windows for those she saved, dark for those she lost or left frozen, faint for the ones she has not reached yet.
- **What a fork carries:** the choice in Stage 1 travels with her. Warm the lantern and she carries its flame, which will light the dark ice cave in Stage 2. Warm the weaver and the weaver knows the way through the wind in Stage 2.
- **Companions strengthen the pulse:** each companion adds one to every pulse, so thawing goes faster, and widens the pulse ring. They do not restore warmth.
- **Relapse:** if warmth stays below 6% for 4 seconds, the most recent companion's fire goes out and they freeze where they stand. Warming them again takes 8 pulses. Neglect has a cost, but it can be undone.
- **The ending:** built in Stage 5. She returns to the village, everyone she saved lights their own window, the homes of those she lost stay dark, and the frost clears to show the view from her own window. It must never look like Journey's ending (no collapse in the snow, no revival by other figures).

Hazards and disasters

All danger comes from the cold itself, never from weapons or traps, and every hazard warns the player before it hits.

Hazard	What it does	Warning sign	How to survive	Status
Katabatic wind	Gusts in waves, pushes the child back, drains warmth fast, breaks a pulse	Snow streaks sideways, rising howl	Move between gusts, shelter behind rocks, or stand still to brace	Built (Stages 2, 5)
Crevasse fall	Snow bridge collapses, the child drops into the ice cave and must walk the way back	Faint glint and a thin crack on the snow, creaking	Keep moving across, never stop or pulse on it	Built (Stage 2)
Avalanche	Snow pours down a chute across the path and buries anyone outside shelter, or a wanderer	Deep rumble, ground shaking, small slides first	Get under the rock overhang or out of the run; dig out by pulsing	Built (Stages 3, 5)
Whiteout	Blowing snow hides almost everything, the cracks most of all	Snowfall thickens, the wind rises	Navigate by the hum of frozen things, the shimmer and the miller's warnings	Built (Stages 4, 5)
Thin ice	Breaks under her if she stops or pulses, drops her into freezing water	Dark clear ice, cracks, creaking	Keep moving; wait at the edge of open water until it freezes over	Built (Stages 4, 5)
Frozen mist	Slowly saps warmth while inside it	Pale fog zone	Pass through quickly	Built (Stage 1)
Frost quake	Ground shakes, icicles fall	A short tremor, shadows where each icicle will land	Step out from under the shadows	Built (Stage 3; from the eaves in Stage 5)

Hazard	What it does	Warning sign	How to survive	Status
Ice storm	Glazes the ice so she slides, drains warmth, every pulse thaws less	Freezing rain	Budget extra warmth, stop early	Built (Stages 4, 5)
Ice shelf collapse	Ground breaking away behind her in the finale	—	—	Dropped: the finale brings back the earlier hazards instead

- Rule: five hazards done beautifully beat nine done roughly.

Prologue: The last coal

The game opens on a 60-second prologue set to the jam's theme track: one village, one shared fire, and the coal a child carried home the night the cold came.

Time	What happens	Words
0–7 s	Black, then a fade in on a warm evening: houses with lit windows and smoking chimneys, one shared hearth in the square, small cold-country flowers in golden grass	
8–20 s	Villagers carry coals home from the hearth in clay pots, and their windows light. The child takes hers and sets off	every night, the village shared one fire (written in warm light)
20–45 s	The storm comes with the music's swell: snow on the roofs, the hearth dies, the villagers by the fire freeze, the windows go dark one by one, frost creeps in from the edges	then the cold came, and every hearth went out (written in the frost)
45–58 s	Darkness closes in; the child's coal is the one light left, and the camera pushes in on it	except the coal she carried (written in the frost)

Time	What happens	Words
60 s on	In silence the child rises from the snow in Stage 1, blows on her coal, and its first pulse melts the first patch of frost; "thaw" is written in the frost. The first key press just walks	

Rules

- A concrete village story, not a myth about a people of light, which is Sky's story.
- Taken from Flower: start slow and dark, one small focal light, story told by light and motion, and no cut from cutscene to play.
- A title screen comes first, because browsers only allow sound after a key press: the frosted glass close up, the night hills faint behind it, her coal's light rising through it in time with her heart, and "thaw" written in the frost. The window it belongs to is kept hidden until the ending. Esc skips the prologue.
- The theme track by Jason Grace plays unmodified and is credited in game, in the download's play notes and in the AI log.
- The village in the prologue is where the ending returns.

Stages

Five stages, four main stages plus the finale, rising from silent and alone to a full warm swell, Stage 1 a short opening of about a minute the middle three about 2 minutes each and the finale, the longest and hardest, about 3 to 4, every stage but the finale ending at a fire.

Stage	Mood	Hazards	Key choice	Teaches or delivers
1. The Still	Silent, dark, alone	Frozen mist	The fork: warm the lantern (rest before the mist) or the wanderer beside it (a companion through the mist). The other is lost	Movement, pulsing, warmth drain, blur to lights out, first companion, first fork

Stage	Mood	Hazards	Key choice	Teaches or delivers
2. The Wind	Exposed open plains	Katabatic wind, a hidden crevasse	At the cairn: the ridge (quick, exposed, a snow bridge) or the gully into the ice cave (out of the wind, dark and cold, the smith inside)	Reading wind rhythm, sheltering, first crevasse fall and walk-out
3. The Slopes	Mountains, rumbling, unstable	Avalanche, frost quake	An avalanche has buried the miller: dig them out while the slope lets go again, or keep moving	Reacting to warnings, costly rescues
4. The Lake	Darkest point before the warmth	Thin ice, whiteout, ice storm, the dark	Free the ferryman and the storyteller in the storm, free one, or cross alone	Reading the ice, the biggest sacrifice
5. Home (finale)	The way home: the hardest stretch, then the full warm swell	Every earlier hazard returns, with her coal capped at 70%	None new: who comes home was decided on the way. Lighting the hearth takes everyone's fire	The village relit, the ending

Stage 2: The Wind (built)

Layout by Ultraviolet. About 2 minutes. She walks on from Stage 1's fire with everyone still with her; Space at the Stage 1 end starts it with the frost transition below.

Between stages: the frost transition

No cut to black. Pressing Space at a stage end runs one continuous move, about 6 seconds:

1. **She sets off.** She and her companions walk on out of the firelight; the end screen and its closing line fade.

2. **The window frosts over.** Frost creeps in from the screen edges with a ragged, crystalline front (the same growth as in the prologue) until the glass is white. The wind rises and the fire's music fades.
3. **The stage changes behind the frost,** so the player never sees the swap.
4. **The thaw.** Her coal pulses and the melt spreads out from her with an uneven edge, revealing the next stage. Its name ("the wind") is written into the last of the frost, and the wind settles.

- **Control:** returns about 1.4 seconds into the thaw.
- **Why frost:** it ties the change of stage to the game's own look and to the prologue, instead of a generic fade.
- **Stage ends:** every stage end now walks on to the next. Stage 5 ends the walk at the hearth instead of a fire.

Part	What happens
Start	Stage 1's fire burned down to coals. A calm stretch, then the first warning and a light gust beside a rock
The plain	Gusts in waves. Rocks every 450 to 600 px give shelter on their left. A frozen tree to warm between gusts or from behind a rock
Before the split	A lantern beside a rock, to warm and rest by before choosing
The cairn	Stones and a red cloth mark the split. Down takes the gully; walking on takes the ridge
Ridge	Quick, strong gusts, nowhere to hide. A snow bridge with a faint glint and a thin crack: stop or pulse on it and it gives way, dropping her (and her companions) into the cave. The landing knocks her coal down by 5 warmth, and she lands about 500 px past the smith: going back for them means walking through the dark, a real risk without the lantern's flame
Gully and ice cave	No wind, but dark, slowly cold and slower to walk. The smith is frozen inside
Rejoin	The shepherd frozen out in the wind, a rock beside them to pulse from. A calm stretch, then the fire

- **The wind:**

    - **Rhythm:** about 6 to 9 seconds of calm, then a 3-second warning (snow streaks sideways, the storm howl rises), then a 4.5-second gust.
    - **What a gust does:** pushes her back, strips warmth and breaks a pulse (let go and press again). The warning is visible and audible from its first moment.
    - **Shelter:** behind a rock none of that reaches her. Out in the open, standing still makes her brace: she crouches and leans into the wind and is not blown back, but still loses warmth (bracing is borrowed from Never Alone, where you brace against blizzard gusts).
- **What Stage 1 changes:**
    - The lantern's flame lights the cave and keeps its cold off.
    - The weaver, if still walking with her, warns of each gust early ("the weaver: wind is coming").
    - With neither, the cave is pitch dark and cold.
- **What it carries forward:** the route is recorded as ridge, gully or fell (through the bridge). The ridge leaves the smith frozen, so the smith's house goes dark in the village row.
- **Lucky embers:** at most 2, never guaranteed.
- **Tested with bots** on every route and Stage 1 outcome; all reached the fire. Lowest warmth: ridge 32 to 45%; gully 61% with the flame, 24% with the weaver, 11% with neither.
- **Changes from the first plan:**
    - **Added:** the lantern before the split, because the stage drained more warmth than she has.
    - **Dropped:** a warm spring in the cave, which made the gully better in every way.
- **Text to confirm or rewrite:** the frost lines ("the wind comes in waves", "hide behind the rocks", "down for the long way, under the ice", "the wind breaks your pulse"), the closing line ("the wind has dropped, for now") and the three route lines on the stage end.

Stage 3: The Slopes (built)

Layout by Ultraviolet. About 2 minutes, reached from Stage 2's fire through the frost transition. The path is a climb: about 300 px up in steep pitches with flat landings, to a high point at the lantern, then down past the miller to the fire. She slows uphill (to about 75% on the pitches, never below half) and moves a little quicker downhill, and the far hills sink lower on the screen as she climbs. The camera does not scroll vertically, so 300 px is about the most the screen can show.

Part	What happens
Foothills	She sets off from Stage 2's burned-out fire. A far-off slide pours down a distant hillside: the warning signs, seen once in safety ("the mountain is waking")
First avalanche run	A broad, uneven mountainside with a paler chute down to the path, and a rock overhang partway across
Frost quake cliffs	An overhanging cliff with icicles above the path
Lantern	A rest before the hard part
The buried miller	A mound of snow with the glow of their pot showing through, beside a second avalanche run with its own overhang
Descent	A calm walk down to the fire

- **Avalanches:**
  - **Warning:** the ground rumbles and shakes, and small slides trickle down the chute for 4 seconds.
  - **The slide:** snow pours down and a wall of powder sweeps across the path.
  - **Shelter:** under the overhang the hollow stays clear; outside it, she is buried.
- **Buried:** the screen turns to snow with a small pocket of air around her, "pulse to dig yourself out" is written on it, and each pulse widens the pocket. It takes 6 pulses alone, and she keeps losing warmth while buried. Not instant death.
- **Frost quakes:** the ground shakes for about 1.5 seconds and shadows show where each icicle will land, then they fall. A hit costs about 8 warmth and knocks her back. The tension: overhangs shelter from avalanches, but the cliff's icicles hang over the path.
- **The miller (the stage's choice):**
  - **Digging:** takes 14 pulses.
  - **The slope lets go again:** about 12 seconds after she arrives, the second run rumbles. She runs for the overhang, and the slide undoes part of the digging ("the snow covers the miller again").
  - **Or keep moving:** the miller is left, and their house goes dark in the village row. The stage end says which.
- **What Stage 2 changes:**

    - **The shepherd** warns of each avalanche early ("the shepherd: the slope is moving"), 6 seconds instead of 4.
    - **The smith** digs twice as fast, for herself or the miller.
- **Lucky embers:** at most 3, never guaranteed.
- **Sound:**
    - **The rumble:** the storm recording played at half speed.
    - **Avalanches and quakes:** the ice cracks played lower.
    - **Icicles:** the ice cracks played higher.
    - All human recordings, credited.
- **Tested with bots:** every run reached the fire with no lights out. Lowest warmth: digging the miller out alone 18%, with the shepherd 47%, with the smith 63%; leaving the miller 40%.
- **Text to confirm or rewrite:** the frost lines ("the mountain is waking", "when it rumbles, get under the rock", "when the ground shakes, step out from under the ice", "the miller is under the snow"), the closing line ("the mountain is quiet again") and the two end-screen lines about the miller.

Stage 4: The Lake (built)

Layout by Ultraviolet: the climax before the finale, made hard on purpose. About 2 minutes, reached from Stage 3's fire through the frost transition. A frozen lake between two shores, at night, with no lantern anywhere.

Part	What happens
Near shore	She sets off from Stage 3's burned-out fire. The ice begins, and the first thin patches ("never stop on thin ice")
Thin ice	Eleven patches of thin, dark ice across the lake. Between them the ice is thick and safe
The whiteout	Blowing snow closes in until almost nothing shows but a little space around her, and the cracks hardly show ("listen to the ice")
The ice storm	Freezing rain: the ice is glazed and she slides on when she stops, it drains warmth, and every pulse thaws less
The group	The ferryman and the old storyteller, frozen together in the middle of the storm ("the ferryman and the storyteller, frozen together")

Part	What happens
Far shore	The fire ("The far shore. Something warm is close now.")

- **The dark:** the darkest stage. She sees by her own coal; the lantern's flame, if carried from Stage 1, lets her see further. Lucky embers and the far fire still show through the dark.
- **The cold:** the open lake takes a little extra warmth everywhere away from heat.
- **Thin ice:**
  - Standing still on it for under a second, or pulsing on it, breaks it. It creaks louder the longer she stands.
  - Falling through costs 25 warmth. She hauls herself out a little way back and is stunned for a moment ("the ice gave way").
  - The hole stays open water for 6 seconds. She stops at its edge instead of going back in ("open water. wait for it to freeze over"), and it visibly skins over before it is thin ice again.
- **The group (the stage's choice):** 10 pulses each, out in the storm where each pulse thaws less. Free both, one or neither; the stage end says which.
- **What earlier stages change:**
  - The miller, if dug out in Stage 3, warns of each thin patch before she reaches it ("the miller: the ice is thin here"), even in the whiteout.
  - The lantern's flame lights the dark further and shows the cracks close to her in the whiteout.
- **Lucky embers:** at most 3, never guaranteed.
- **Tested with bots:** crossing alone, lowest warmth 44%; freeing both with two companions 25%; with four companions and the flame 12 to 16%; freeing both alone puts the light out. A gameplay check found that walking on after a fall dropped her straight back into the open hole until her light went out; fixed by the edge stop above.
- **Text to confirm or rewrite:** the frost lines ("never stop on thin ice", "listen to the ice", "the ferryman and the storyteller, frozen together", "the ice gave way", "open water. wait for it to freeze over"), the closing line and the three end-screen lines about the group.

Stage 5: Home (built, the finale)

Layout by Ultraviolet, with these changes to the first draft: longer, the hardest stage, at most 3 lucky embers, and the homes of the lost stay dark. About 3 to 4 minutes: the longest stage (10,300 px; the lake is 8,300). The village from the prologue, at the end of the walk.

Part	What happens
The road	The wind is back, stronger than on the plains, with the rocks further apart. A tree to warm
The pass	Above the village: an avalanche run with a rock overhang ("the slope above the village is waking"), then a cliff path with frost quakes
The lantern	The only one, at the top of the pass: the last rest before the village
The millpond	Thin ice under a whiteout ("thin ice, and the snow coming down")
The street	Seven homes in an ice storm, with icicles falling from the eaves; the doors and the gaps between homes are clear ("home")
The square	The village tree and the hearth, open to the wind ("light the hearth")

- **The failing coal:** her warmth never goes past 70% here, not at the lantern, not from an ember. The warmth bar shows the part it can no longer reach, and the frost says so at the start ("her coal is fading. it will not burn full again").
- **Homes:** each villager walking with her goes to their own door and lights their window from their pot, then falls in behind her again ("the baker is home"). The homes of those she lost stay dark.
- **The hearth:** the shared fire that went out in the prologue, its stones iced over. It takes 30 pulses alone; every companion's fire adds to each pulse, so with all seven it takes 4. The square is open to the wind, so gusts break the pulse.
- **The village tree:** warmed (3 pulses), it warms her back while she lights the hearth, and it is where she wakes if her light goes out in the square.
- **Every earlier carry-over still works:** the shepherd warns of the avalanche, the smith digs faster, the miller warns of thin ice, the lantern's flame shows the cracks in the whiteout.
- **Lucky embers:** at most 3, never guaranteed.
- **Tested with bots:** every run reached the hearth. With all seven, lowest warmth 14 to 20%, arriving at the square at 25 to 34%; with three, 9%; alone, 0 to 8%, one run's light going out once (it woke at the lantern and finished). The hardest stage, as intended.
- **Text to confirm or rewrite:** the frost lines above and the four ending lines (see Choices and endings).

Saving, checkpoints and replay (built)

- **Saving:** the walk is saved in the browser at the start of every stage. The title offers "press any key to continue" (naming the stage), N for a new walk, or the number of any stage reached, played as things stood when it began. "Start over from the beginning" forgets only the walk in progress. If the browser blocks storage, the game plays the same without remembering.
- **Checkpoints:** a lit lantern, a freed villager or the warmed village tree in Stage 5 becomes where she wakes after lights out, said once in the frost ("if your light goes out, you will wake here").
- **Missed people:** walk on well past someone still frozen and the frost names them, once: "the miller is still under the snow back there", "the ferryman and the old storyteller are still frozen back there", or "someone was down in the cave" if she never went in.
- **The record:** finishing records the best walk (brought home, trees warmed) and the endings found, shown on the title and at the end ("a new ending").

Pulsing in time, and companions with a presence (built)

- **In time with her heart:** holding pulse still pulses on every heartbeat. A press within 0.15 seconds of a heartbeat is in time: it thaws half as much again and costs half the warmth, with a brighter breath and a gold ring. Nothing pulses faster than the heart, so tapping quickly does nothing extra. Stage 1 teaches it once ("pulse in time with her heart"; the first time: "in time with her heart, a pulse goes further").
- **Waking:** each villager wakes with one sung note on the glass at their own pitch, and a line of their own written beside them (drafts, to confirm or rewrite):
  - The weaver: "i heard you coming. the wind talks, if you listen"
  - The baker: "your hands are so small. walk with me"
  - The smith: "i was dreaming of my forge"
  - The shepherd: "the slopes are restless. stay close to me"
  - The miller: "i know the weight of ice. i will tell you where it is thin"
  - The ferryman: "i have crossed this lake a thousand times"
  - The old storyteller: "so this is how the story goes on"
- **At each fire:** everyone walking with her gathers round it, on both sides.
- **Lines in the frost:** a new line waits for the one showing to finish where both matter (a waking line, the first checkpoint), and at a stage's end the frost is left to the closing words.

Fixes from the full inspection (built)

- **Choices cost something:** losing her light costs the last companion (see Respawn). Stage 2 has a tree up on the ridge that only the ridge can reach, so the route is the smith against a tree rather than the gully being better in every way. A pulse reaches only its own floor.
- **Every companion brings something:**
  - The weaver: warns of gusts.
  - The shepherd: warns of avalanches.
  - The smith: digs twice as fast.
  - The miller: warns of thin ice.
  - The baker: she cools 10% more slowly.
  - The ferryman: no sliding on glazed ice, and the thin ice holds longer.
  - The old storyteller: no one's fire goes out.
- **Help for a smaller group:** more lucky embers while she walks with one companion or none.
- **Less repetition, less waiting:** lines that teach something are written once a visit, and gusts last 3.5 seconds instead of 4.5. Stage 5's wind is stronger so it stays the hardest stage (bots: lowest warmth 8 to 20% with a small group, 34% with all six).
- **Performance:** the frost's colour is drained after the scene is shrunk, not before; frames are about 40% faster without a GPU. If frames still come slowly the game drops to low detail (no canvas filters) for the rest of the visit. Still to check on a real laptop.
- **Settings and reach:** volume (- and +) and screen shake (X), remembered between visits; touch controls (hold left or right to walk, the middle to pulse, swipe down for the low way); a note to turn a phone sideways; larger small text; a stronger heartbeat glow on her coal for playing without sound; the theme starts loading on the title screen.
- **Jam page:** screenshots, a GIF of the ending and the itch.io page text are in the repository's press folder.

From research into comparable games (built)

Research into Gris, Celeste, Limbo, A Short Hike, Journey and Spiritfarer: no lost progress on failure, an opt-in harder or gentler mode with no judgement, difficulty the player sets through play, an optional secret for completionists, rest beats before a climax, and time with companions.

- **A gentle or a hard walk:** H on the title or pause screen, remembered. On a gentle walk her light going out costs the last companion; on a hard walk the stage begins again. The endings are the same either way.

- **The secret ending:** bring all seven home and warm every tree (seven, counting the ridge's). The dawn is amber like the prologue's evening, blossom grows, sparks rise from the hearth, and the line is "every window, every tree. the village shares one fire again" (draft). The title records it.
- **A calm beat in Stage 5:** the first two homes in the street have no storm or icicles, a breath before the hardest stretch.
- **Words by the fire:** at each stage's fire, whoever joined in that stage (or the last to join) says something about home (drafts):
  - The weaver: "there is a cloth on my loom, half woven. i will finish it for you"
  - The baker: "when we are home, i will bake for the whole street"
  - The smith: "my forge will take three days to wake. i will sit with it"
  - The shepherd: "i hope the flock found the barn before the snow did"
  - The miller: "the mill wheel will be frozen solid. we will thaw it together"
  - The ferryman: "from my door you can see the whole lake. it will be water again"
  - The old storyteller: "i have a new story now. it is about a child and a coal"

How to play, phones, and the submission (built)

- **How to play:** after the prologue, a page on the frosted glass covers walking, pulsing (and in time), warmth, companions, warnings, losing her light (it changes with gentle or hard) and the keys.
  - "Begin" unlocks after 3 seconds of reading, shown by a line that fills; "skip" works at once. The press that skipped the prologue cannot skip it too.
  - Skipped by mistake: a ? button beside the full-screen one during the walk, the ? or I key, and "how to play" on the pause screen open it again, and it closes back to where the player was.
- **Phones:**
  - Sound runs through Web Audio when the game is served from a website, so fades, mixing and the volume setting work on iPhones (which ignore an audio element's volume). Opened from disk, it keeps the audio elements' own volume. Sound starts inside the first tap.
  - On a touch screen the words speak of taps (the tutorial, the opening title's controls, the prompts, "tap to skip"), the touch zones glow faintly until she has walked and pulsed, a pause button sits in the corner, and the title and pause screens have tappable buttons for every setting.
  - Small text scales up on small screens (about 1.5 times on a phone), and a phone held upright is asked to turn sideways.

- **Performance on slow devices:** low detail now also draws the scene at 70% size and the screen at the device's base resolution, and rebuilds the frost every other frame. It is detected from real frame times, so a very slow device is caught within about a second. On a simulated phone without a graphics chip: 20 to 28 fps before, 47 to 57 after. Still to try on a real iPhone and Android phone.
- **Submission materials:** in the repository's press folder: seven screenshots, two covers at 630 by 500 (frames from the game with the title in its own font), a GIF of the ending and the itch.io page text. A 10:51 walkthrough video from the title to the ending, recorded on the final build, for an unlisted YouTube link. The design statement, game instructions and AI usage statement were drafted for the jam form (the in-game text is disclosed as drafted by the AI and chosen by Ultraviolet).

The ending (built)

1. The hearth catches. Everyone with her gathers around the fire, on both sides, and the jam's theme plays again from the top, unmodified, as it opened the game.
2. The frost clears from the whole screen for the first time.
3. Dawn: the sky warms from the horizon up and the falling snow thins.
4. The ground greens as much as trees were warmed across the whole walk: bare earth, then grass, then flowers.
5. The window frame of her own home closes in around the view, with her clay pot glowing on the sill: the frosted glass the whole walk was seen through was her window.
6. One line is written for the ending, then "thaw", then how many she brought home, the trees warmed and the endings found.
7. Any key goes back to the title, where the walk is remembered.
8. Never like Journey's ending: she never collapses in the snow, is never lifted or revived by others, and never walks into a light.

Art, audio and originality

The look is frosted glass: the whole world sits behind frost, like a window in winter, and warmth melts clear patches where color and detail show through. Hints, the title and closing lines are written into the frost, like a finger on a cold window.

Art direction

- **Palette:** Teal-slate night sky, pale snow, dark figures and trees, amber firelight. Color shows only where the frost has melted. The night turns slowly toward dawn across the five stages: a little more warmth low in the sky ahead of her with each one, and fewer stars, until the ending's dawn completes it. Each stage also has its own far

landmark, so a single screenshot says where she is: a crescent moon over the Still, snow banners streaming off the ridges in the Wind, a high snow-capped range behind the Slopes, the ferry frozen into the Lake beside its pier, and the village rooftops on a far ridge on the way Home.

- **Shapes:** Dark silhouettes against bright snow, with forested ridges for depth. Hand-drawn silhouettes from the team replace code-drawn ones wherever possible.
- **Light:** Glow, particles and shaders do the heavy lifting. Warm light (fires, lanterns) is always the goal.
- **Scale:** The child stays small in wide, empty spaces to sell the isolation.
- **UI:** One slim warmth bar, nothing else. The coal in her pot repeats what the bar shows.

Audio direction

- Start near-silent: wind, ice creaks, a slow heartbeat.
- The stage music starts faint and grows fuller with every thaw, so the music builds as the player progresses.
- Wide dynamic range from silence to swell, like the theme track.
- The theme track may be used only unmodified and only inside the jam entry.

Where the audio comes from

No sound in the game is synthesized or AI-generated. Everything is the jam's theme or a human-made recording, credited in the game files (audio/CREDITS.md) and the download's play notes.

- **Rule:** only CC0 (or CC-BY with credit) music and recordings, uploaded before 2022 or with a clear statement that they are human-made. Clips may be cut, leveled, faded and filtered, nothing more.
- **Theme:** the jam's track by Jason Grace, played unmodified in the prologue.
- **Music** (CC0, OpenGameArt):
  - "Long Winter" by Indieteur: the stage music. Faint at first, fuller with every thaw, full after five.
  - "Esther" by Kistol: a darker piano that takes over as warmth falls from 35% to 15%. Silence when the light goes out.
  - "November Snow" by cynicmusic: rest at the fire, and the prologue's music if the theme cannot load.
- **Sound effects** (CC0 recordings, Freesound):
  - Wind through a window everywhere for now; a howling winter storm saved for the wind hazards from Stage 2.
  - Ice cracking when a pulse lands, meltwater drips when something thaws, frozen trees cracking when the cold takes what you did not choose.

- Boots crunching in snow on every step, a slow recorded heartbeat, her breath on the coal when she pulses.
- A rubbed wine glass as the hum of frozen things, pitched differently for trees, lanterns and people.
- A singing bowl when a companion joins or the fire is reached, a crackle of fire for a lucky ember, the fire itself at the stage end, and a candle blown out when her light goes out.

Originality rules (inspiration, never copying)

- Reference games studied: Gris (color returning as progress, no HUD, slow pace) and Celeste (snowy setting, warm light in the cold).
- Never reuse their art, music, text or characters, and never recreate their scenes.
- Our differences: a heartbeat pulse mechanic, a child bundled in a quilted coat, hood and striped scarf, with visible arms holding a clay pot of coal (not Journey's armless robed traveler, not Sky's people of light), a concrete village-hearth story, firelight amber instead of watercolor red, connection instead of grief, a frosted-glass world instead of watercolor. Color returns only through melted frost, never as a whole-world repaint, which keeps us clear of Flower.
- Screenshot test: if a judge would name another game from a screenshot, change it.

Controls and tech

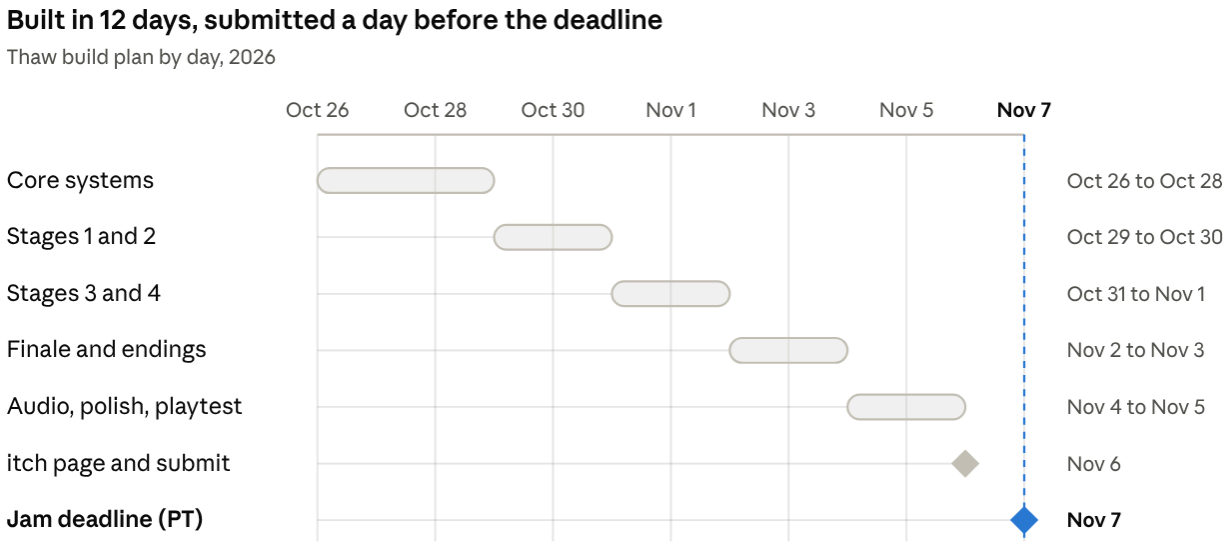
Two inputs run the whole game: walk and pulse.

Action	Keyboard	Gamepad	Touch
Walk	Left and Right arrows, or A and D	Left stick	Hold the left or right of the screen
Pulse (hold)	Space	A button	Hold the middle of the screen
Low way at a cairn	Down or S	Down	Swipe down in the middle
Pause	Esc or P	Start	The button in the corner
How to play	? or I	—	The ? button
Volume, shake, walk	- and +, X, H	—	Buttons on the pause screen
Mute, full screen	M, F	—	The full-screen button

- **Engine:** Plain JavaScript with HTML5 Canvas (or Phaser if the team prefers a framework)
- **Effects:** Canvas compositing and blur filters for glow, frost and the lights-out sequence
- **Audio:** Recorded audio files played through plain audio elements, so sound also works when the game is opened straight from disk. Loops crossfade over their seam
- **Build target:** One web build uploaded to itch.io, played in the browser
- **Performance target:** Smooth on a mid-range laptop browser

Schedule and cut list

The build runs from October 26 to a November 6 submission, leaving November 7 as a one-day buffer before the deadline.



Thaw build plan · 6 phases and the deadline

All stages share the same core systems, so most later work is level layout and tuning, not new code.

Build priority (if time runs short, work top down)

1. Warmth as HP with the warmth bar, plus the blur to lights-out
2. Fires as checkpoints and respawn
3. Choice puzzles and companions
4. Hazards: katabatic wind, crevasse, avalanche, then whiteout and thin ice
5. Ending variations

Cut list (first to go)

- Nothing left to cut: the ice storm and frost quakes are built.

- Dropped: the ice shelf collapse. The finale brings back every earlier hazard instead.

Submission checklist

- [ ] Web build uploaded to itch.io (HTML, played in the browser, 1280 by 720, full-screen button, mobile friendly in landscape) and tested in a fresh browser
- [ ] Game page with title, tagline, description, controls, cover and screenshots (all in the press folder)
- [ ] AI disclosure on the form: Graphics, Code, and Text and Dialog ticked, with the statement of AI usage
- [ ] Design statement, game instructions and walkthrough video link on the jam form
- [ ] All team members added before submissions close
- [ ] Theme track used unmodified
- [ ] Music and sound credits on the game page, matching audio/CREDITS.md
- [ ] One try on a real iPhone and Android phone